

Managing Omeka S Modules

This guide explains what modules are, which modules are bundled with Arlington Stories, and how a repository maintainer and an Omeka administrator work together to add one.

For the standard Omeka interface, see the official [Modules Management](#) guide, which includes screenshots.

The short version

Modules cannot be uploaded through the Omeka admin interface. In this project:

1. A repository maintainer downloads a compatible release ZIP and places it in `plugins/`.
2. The project's Docker startup script extracts new module ZIPs into Omeka.
3. A Global Administrator opens **Admin** → **Modules** and installs or activates the module.

If you are an archive editor and need a module that is not listed under **Modules**, send the module name and its download page to the repository maintainer. Do not download an arbitrary ZIP or source-code snapshot yourself.

Three module states

It helps to distinguish three similar-sounding states:

- **Bundled** means a release ZIP is stored in this repository's `plugins/` directory. It will be available whenever the project is deployed from the repository.
- **Installed** means Omeka has registered the module and run any database setup it requires.
- **Active** means the installed module's features are currently enabled.

The **Admin** → **Modules** page is the authoritative place to check whether a bundled module is installed and active. A ZIP in the repository does not prove that the module has been activated on every deployment.

Activate a module that is already bundled

Only a Global Administrator can install, activate, deactivate, or configure modules. Other account roles may have less access.

1. Log in to the Omeka admin dashboard.
2. Select **Modules** in the left navigation.
3. Find the module by name.
4. Follow the action shown beside it:
 - **Install** registers the module and normally activates it automatically.
 - **Activate** enables a module that is installed but inactive.
 - **Configure** opens settings for a module that provides them.
5. Confirm that Omeka displays a success message.
6. Test the relevant admin feature and its public display.

If Omeka reports a missing dependency, install or activate the dependency first. For example, **Block Plus** requires **Common**.

Deactivate is not the same as uninstall. Deactivation turns features off while preserving the module's data. Uninstalling may delete module-created database tables and data. Do not uninstall a module without a backup and a specific removal plan.

Add a new module to the project

These steps require repository and deployment access and are intended for a maintainer.

1. Find and evaluate the module

Start with the official [Omeka S Modules directory](#). Before downloading anything, confirm:

- the release supports **Omeka S 4.2** (the version used by this project);
- it comes from the module's official download or releases page;
- all required dependencies are available;
- its maintenance status, documentation, license, and support channel are acceptable; and
- its feature does not duplicate something already provided by Omeka core or a bundled module.

Download a packaged **release ZIP**, not a repository's “source code” archive. Release packages may contain dependencies that are absent from source snapshots.

2. Add the ZIP to plugins/

Keep the module name and version in the filename, following the existing convention:

`plugins/ModuleName-1.2.3.zip`

The ZIP should expand to one top-level module directory whose name does not include a version number—for example, `Mapping/`, not `Mapping-2.2.0/`.

3. Restart the Omeka service

From the repository root:

```
docker compose restart omeka-s
```

The `plugins/` directory is mounted inside the container at `/srv/plugins`. On startup, `docker/omeka-s/install-modules.sh` extracts any new ZIP whose module directory is not already present.

To verify what happened:

```
docker compose logs omeka-s
```

Look for `Installing module: ModuleName` or `Module already installed: ModuleName`.

4. Install or activate it in Omeka

The repository step makes the module available; it does not complete Omeka's database installation. A Global Administrator must finish the process under **Admin** → **Modules**.

5. Test before publishing

Test the module in the local or staging environment before deploying it to production. At minimum, verify:

- installation and activation complete without errors;
- existing admin and public pages still load;
- the new feature works with this theme;
- pages remain usable at desktop and mobile widths; and
- deactivation returns the site to a working state.

Commit the release ZIP and any required theme integration together so future deployments remain reproducible.

Updating an existing module

Adding a new module and upgrading an existing one are different operations. The startup script deliberately does **not** overwrite an existing module directory, so replacing a ZIP with a newer version and restarting is not sufficient.

Plan upgrades with a maintainer. Back up the database and current module, check the module's upgrade instructions, replace the deployed module directory safely, and then use the **Upgrade** action under **Admin** → **Modules**. Never use `docker compose down -v` as an upgrade method: it deletes the project database and other persistent volumes.

See Omeka's [Updating a module](#) instructions for the general process.

Worked example: how Mapping was added

Mapping is the module that adds locations to items and interactive maps to sites.

For this project:

1. The official `Mapping-2.2.0.zip` release was added to `plugins/`.
2. Docker mounts that directory at `/srv/plugins` in the Omeka container.
3. The startup script extracts the ZIP as `/var/www/html/modules/Mapping` when the module is not already present.
4. A Global Administrator installs or activates **Mapping** under **Admin** → **Modules**.
5. Mapping adds a **Mapping** tab to the item editor, map page blocks, and a **Map Browse** navigation option.
6. The theme's `mapping/site/index/browse.phtml` override gives the public Map Browse page the Arlington Stories presentation while preserving Mapping's scripts and styles.

Editors can then add locations from an item's **Mapping** tab. See [Putting an interview on the map](#) for the content workflow.

Modules currently bundled

The following release ZIPs are currently stored in `plugins/`. Their installation and activation state may differ by deployment.

Module	Version	What it provides
Activity Log	1.0.1	Records user activity for administrative review.
Advanced Search	3.4.61	Adds richer search fields, filters, facets, and search pages.

Module	Version	What it provides
Block Plus	3.4.45	Adds page models and advanced editorial blocks; requires Common.
Bulk Edit	3.4.39	Adds advanced batch metadata cleanup and editing tools.
Clean URL	3.17.14	Provides configurable, human-readable resource URLs.
Common	3.4.86	Supplies shared infrastructure required by several other modules.
Custom Vocab	2.1.0	Lets administrators create controlled lists of metadata values.
Faceted Browse	1.9.2	Adds filterable, faceted browsing pages.
Feed	3.4.9	Produces RSS and Atom feeds for selected pages or resources.
Google Analytics	1.3.1	Adds Google Analytics tracking when configured.
Mapping	2.2.0	Adds item locations, interactive maps, map blocks, and map browsing.
Metadata Browse	1.6.1	Links metadata values to resources sharing the same value.
Resource Meta	1.1.0	Adds configurable metadata tags to public resource pages.
Rights Statements	1.2.1	Adds RightsStatements.org choices for rights metadata.
Sharing	1.5.0	Adds tools for sharing and embedding public content.
Sitemaps	1.1	Generates site-specific XML sitemaps for search engines.
Statistics	3.4.14	Adds administrative counts and statistics about resources.
Universal Viewer	3.6.15-4.2.1	Provides a unified viewer for images, PDFs, audiovisual files, and IIIF content.

Troubleshooting

The module does not appear under Admin → Modules

- Confirm that its ZIP exists in `plugins/`.
- Confirm that the Omeka container restarted after the ZIP was added.
- Check `docker compose logs omeka-s` for extraction errors.
- Inspect the ZIP structure: it must contain one correctly named module directory, not an extra wrapper directory.
- Confirm that the module supports Omeka S 4.2 and the server's PHP version.

Omeka reports a missing dependency

Locate the dependency in `plugins/`, install or activate it first, then retry the original module. Consult the module's release documentation for version requirements.

A module is present but its feature is missing

Check whether the module is merely installed but inactive. Some modules also require configuration, a site setting, a navigation entry, or a particular page block before anything appears publicly.

Related documentation

- Building and Editing Site Pages
- Adding an Oral History
- Omeka S: Modules Management
- Omeka S Modules directory
- Omeka S: Mapping

- Developer notes